7.13 'Leithon', The Netherlands

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Location and surroundings

In the village of Leiderdorp (near The Hague and Leiden) in the western part of the Netherlands the remains of an early medieval settlement (Merovingian and Carolingian) is scheduled as national archaeological monument (Fig.64). The region between the villages of Katwijk (in the west) and Koudekerk (in the east) is known for the presence of numerous archaeological remains from Roman and early medieval period located at the former river course/ estuary of the Oude Rijn river, part of the Rhine delta. This region is one of the most densely populated area of the Netherlands, so over the past decades numerous archaeological excavations have been executed. In general the impetus for this research was spatial developments (construction of infrastructure, building of houses, etc.). Until the beginning of the twentieth century the site was located in the outskirts of Leiderdorp. Since 1937 the terrain on which the site is located was in use as tennis courts. The research history of the early medieval site 'Leithon' and its surroundings in Leiderdorp already started in the 1950s when an excavation was done by the curator of the National Museum of Antiquities in Leiden. During that excavation the remains of an early medieval settlement were discovered but also wooden and stone constructions along the residual river channels near the settlement. In the 1980s, human remains were found as well as animal bones (settlement consumption waste and butchering refuse) in a former channel.

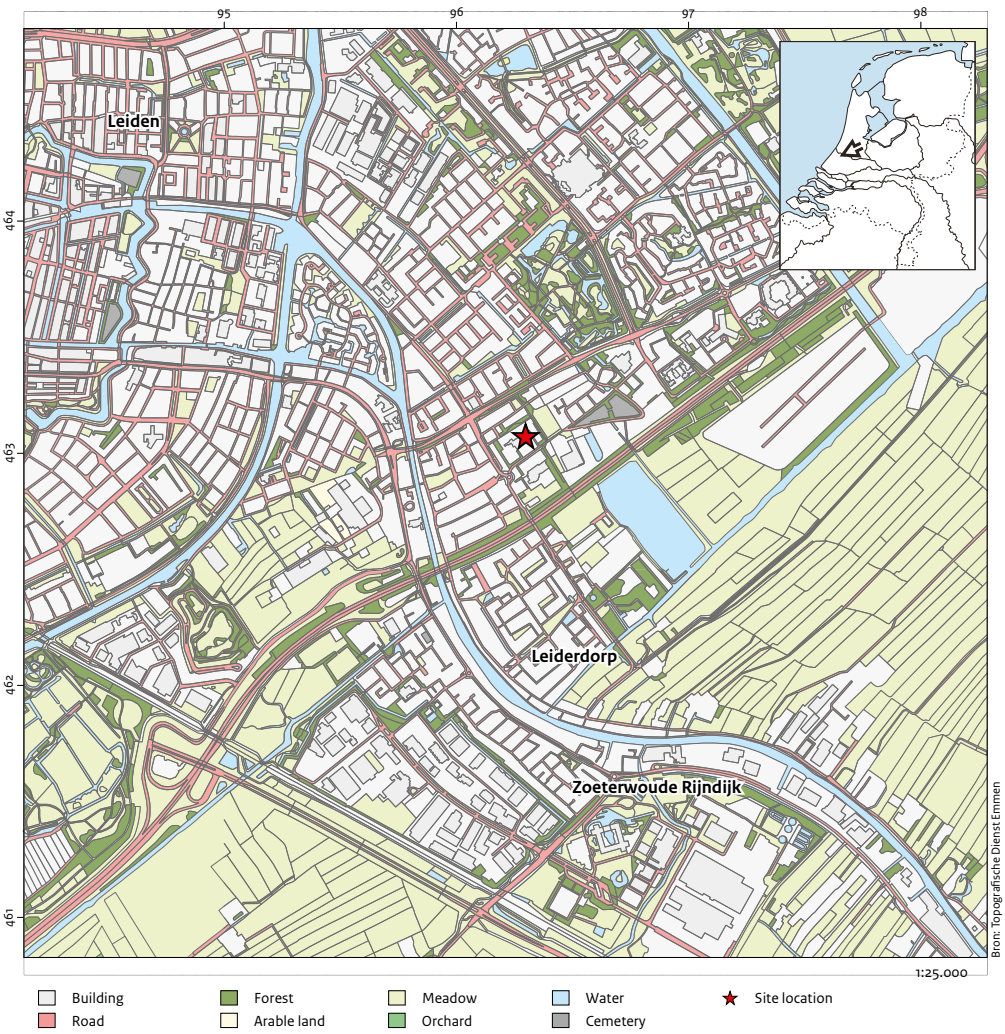

Figure 64: Location of the listed archaeological monument in Leiderdorp (Courtesy Cultural Heritage Agency of the Netherlands)

Reasons for assessment

At the beginning of this century it was decided that the (open) area of the tennis courts which was surrounded by houses was to be developed as residential area with numerous new houses. The archaeological remains are situated in the subsurface only about 40cm below the present surface and in fact directly below the tennis courts. As a result the question arose: what to do with the important archaeological site of 'Leithon', preserve or excavate?

The majority of archaeological remains in the Netherlands, are invisible because they are situated below the surface. However, the characteristics of the subsurface of the Netherlands and then especially the Holocene parts of the Netherlands (western and northern Netherlands and riverine areas in the central and southern Netherlands) leads to good to excellent preservation of (organic) archaeological remains. So for large parts of the Netherlands archaeological remains and objects are very well preserved[24]. If one would visit these Roman monuments in the Netherlands the majority of these sites are below your feet underground and their location and significance is marked through signs, information panels, 'reconstructions' and visualizations of what these remains exemplify.

The site of 'Leithon' is thus located in the area with generally good preservation if remains are not yet destroyed by later activities. The presence of well-preserved bone, wood and other organic remains related to the Early Medieval settlement shows the good conservation conditions on the site. For decades it was known that underneath the tennis courts and its surroundings significant archaeological remains are present. Because of the fact that in this – nowadays highly urbanized – part of the Netherlands these valuable early medieval archaeological remains are still present below the surface, the area of Leiderdorp gained the attention of both archaeologists and heritage resource managers (national and local). The settlement of Leithon might be regarded as relic or representation of the (former) dense clusters of archaeological remains from this period in the wider highly urbanized area.

Entirely conforming to the principles of the Valletta Convention, the initial premise was to leave these archaeological remains 'in situ' and in this safeguard them from future developments and destruction.

Other motives and aspects also have to be dealt with in heritage management especially when spatial development (in this instance new houses) is necessary. Furthermore at a national level it was observed that Early Medieval settlements (with well preserved (organic) archaeological remains) had been discovered in the past decades in the area. However most sites were excavated and only a few scheduled as national monuments. Therefore the settlement in Leiderdorp was designated to become a scheduled archaeological monument to preserve remains of this type.

Firstly, this decision needed to be coordinated with local authorities and plans for the site, because originally, the plan had entailed the complete destruction of the archaeological site. Fortunately the building plans were adapted and a new plan which entailed the combination of new housing and recreation was developed. The Cultural Heritage Agency of the Netherlands and the local government of Leiderdorp came to the following agreement or compromise: the area of the archaeological site which was to be built over was to be professionally excavated, and the area of the site where the tennis courts were was to become a scheduled archaeological monument where the archaeological remains were left unharmed and a recreational park was to be developed. One could regard this compromise as a loss for the archaeology because yet another part of the early medieval archive in this region was to be destroyed and only a part of the settlement was to be preserved in situ. However, this compromise produced a bonus because the partial excavation means it is now much clearer what exactly is preserved in situ.

Assessing significance- methods and outcomes

For the excavation, an extensive programme of requirements was written by the Cultural Heritage Agency, the municipality of Leiderdorp and researchers from the Amsterdam Archaeological Centre (University of Amsterdam). The researchers from Amsterdam conducted the excavation because it fitted within their framework of research.

[24]This preservation state of the buried archaeological remains was for example one of the key arguments to list the Dutch part of the Lower German Limes as a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

Figure 65: Finds from one of the residual gullies (Courtesy University of Amsterdam)

Figure 66: The excavation of one of the residual gullies showing the remains of revetments (Courtesy University of Amsterdam)

During the excavation (2013) a total of almost 200,000 finds were recorded. For organic finds especially the fill of the residual river channels proved to be a treasure trove. The channels were lined with revetments made of timbers, wickerwork and re-used stone material (Fig.66).

It was possible to use the timbers from these revetments for dendrochronological research, providing very accurate construction dates in both Merovingian and Carolingian periods. An interesting inorganic finds category were the numerous stone fragments. The use of stone material is not that common in Dutch (pre)history, it turned out that the stone material in Leithon mainly was re-used building material which derived from the former Roman fort of Matilo situated about 800 m to the west. This re-used 'Roman' building material was combined with timber in the construction and re-enforcement of the shores of the residual gullies.

Finds from the channels consisted of large quantities of animal bones and pottery, metal objects and metal production refuse, numerous leather finds, bone and antler combs and a lot of rope (Fig.65). Based on the analyses of the finds it is clear that subsistence in the settlement was based on animal husbandry (cattle, sheep/goat, pig and horse) and growing of crops (barley, rye and emmer) with an addition of both salt and freshwater fishing. Possibly a part of the wheats were imported from southern regions.

Numerous personal objects and tools of both metal and organic material were found. A number of wool combs, loom weights and hackles indicate that the processing of wool and flax. Furthermore both objects from iron, bronze and lead were made in the settlement. The pottery assemblage shows resemblance to that from the famous Dorestad settlement with pottery coming from the German Rhineland and Eiffel area. Whereas Dorestad in Carolingian times clearly can be identified as an international trading hub, Leithon cannot be qualified as such, because the residual channels were too small to facilitate large vessels. It is likely the former inhabitants of Leithon participated in the Frisian Trade network that connected the North Sea region with the Carolingian hinterland. Around 840 AD the settlement ceased to exist likely due to a massive storm surge dated to 838. Its features and finds remained hidden until the excavations in 2013.

Conclusion

To conclude, in Leiderdorp, on the banks of two residual channels in the Rhine estuary, the remains of an Early Medieval settlement is located. The settlement is characterized by the presence of revetments lining residual channels and thick pack of find-rich inorganic and organic material in the residual channels. In addition, some skeletons have been found indicating

the presence of at least one burial ground. Probably the settlement in Leiderdorp formed part of a network of early medieval settlements along the coast and in the Rhine estuary participating in the Frisian Trade network. Most of these settlements have completely disappeared and been disrupted due to urbanization in the Western Netherlands. In Leiderdorp part of the site remains in situ and are scheduled as archaeological monument (monument number 532469) (Fig.67). The remains are well-preserved and largely intact in the subsurface and therefore a valuable addition to the archive of listed sites in the Netherlands providing a possibility for research of future generations (Fig.68).

Figure 67: The demarcation of the listed archaeological monument on an aerial photo (Courtesy Cultural Heritage Agency of the Netherlands)

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Figure 68: Part of the listed archaeological monument situated under the recreation area in the suburb of Leiderdorp, the archaeological presence is marked by an artwork depicting some of the pottery found during the excavation (Courtesy Cultural Heritage Agency of the Netherlands)